By Pradip R. Sagar



WEAKENING BIND An aerial view of Gulhi Fahlu in the Maldives; left, Maldives president Mohamed Muizzu; above, suspended ministers (from L) Maryam Shiuna, Malsha Shareef and Mahzoom Majid

AFP

MALDIVES

FREEZING WIND FROM MALE

First, in April 2022, came a giant banner emblazoned on the walls of the former Maldives president and opposition leader Abdulla Yameen Abdul Gayoom's house in Male. Its message was unequivocal: "India Out". Two months later, a mob attacked Yoga Day activities in Male organised by Indian diplomats—for being "un-Islamic". These were early signs of an anti-India sentiment taking hold of the archipelago nation. Maldives president Mohamed Muizzu, who was mayor of Male when these incidents happened, surely took his cue from them. In 2023, he contested the presidential polls on an 'India Out' campaign, demanding a withdrawal of Indian military personnel so as to "ensure the country's sovereignty". So, the latest controversy that erupted on January 7—intemperate reactions to videos and images posted by PM Narendra Modi on social media promoting tourism in Lakshadweep—come with a bit of history. But it has still taken India-Maldives relations to a diplomatic low not often seen before.

Though the PM did not mention the Maldives in his tweets (some social media influencers started promoting Lakshadweep over it as a tourist destination), three deputy ministers in the Maldives' ministry of youth affairs—Maryam Shiuna, Malsha Shareef and Mahzoom Majid—made disparaging remarks about India and its prime minister. After the Indian High Commission in Male expressed concern over the comments that ridiculed India and called PM Modi names, and the attack on a "key ally and time-tested friend" was condemned by former Maldives presidents Ibrahim Mohamed Solih and Mohamed Nasheed, Muizzu's government took action. Before the president boarded a flight to Beijing for a state visit on January 7, the trio of Shiuna, Shareef and Majid stood suspended.

Quickly moving in for damage control, foreign affairs minister Moosa Zameer also put out a statement: "The Government of Maldives is aware of derogatory remarks...against foreign leaders and high-ranking individuals. These opinions are personal and do not represent the views of the Government of Maldives." It also asserted that freedom of expression should be "exercised in a democratic and responsible manner and in ways that do not... hinder close relationships between the Maldives and its international partners". In New Delhi, the Maldivian envoy was summoned to the external affairs ministry, where, too, India's strong concern was conveyed. However, neither PM Modi nor external affairs minister S. Jaishankar have commented on the matter.

The controversy has resulted in an online "boycott Maldives" campaign. Online travel booking portal EaseMyTrip suspended sale of tickets to the Maldives and the Indian Chamber of Commerce on January 8 issued an "appeal to boycott Maldives". Tourism is the mainstay of the Maldives economy and a large slice of its income from it comes from India. Indians made over 209,000 trips to the Maldives in 2023, making up a sizeable 11 per cent of its tourist arrivals—the highest from any country. In 2020, 2021 and 2022, too, Indians formed the single biggest group of tourists to Maldives.

The Maldives is a key maritime